ENEMIES OF ROME

The forces against which the Romans fought ranged from the armies of rival states or empires – including the Carthaginians in the west and the Parthians and Sassanid Persians in the east – to tribal warbands and nomadic cavalry. Although there was never any great technological gulf distinguishing these different forces from one another or from the Romans, they were extremely varied in their battle tactics, their level of organization and discipline, and their view of warfare. The contrast between Celtic or Germanic tribal fighters following their chiefs into battle and the complex polyglot army of Carthage translated into a very different battlefield performance – the Carthaginian army coming close to achieving the conquest of Rome.

THE CARTHAGINIANS

The army with which the inspired Carthaginian general Hannibal invaded Italy in 218 BCE was a multicultural force of mercenaries, chiefly recruited from Carthage's North African allies or tributaries and from Spain. No attempt was made to blend these troops into a uniform force. Instead each ethnic group stuck together and fought in its own style. Libyans made redoubtable foot soldiers, while the semi-nomadic Numidians were superb light horsemen, riding bareback armed with javelins and spears. Spanish hill tribesmen fought mounted or on foot, usually armed with short swords. Balearic Islanders specialized in the use of slingshots, firing a hail of stones or lead pellets. Hannibal's war elephants, a small African breed, were mostly supplied by the Numidians – the beasts served to disrupt enemy cavalry and provided a platform for archers or javelin-throwers.

What held this disparate army together was the shared experience of combat and, above all, allegiance to their commander. The mercenaries would fight forever as long as pay or plunder were available to reward them. At Cannae in 216 BCE Hannibal's army inflicted a thorough and bloody defeat on the Romans, and it sustained its campaign in Italy for 15 years. When the war eventually shifted to North Africa, local conscripts were drafted in to make up a large part of the Carthaginian ranks. This diluted army was definitively defeated by the Romans at Zama in 202 BCE.



ORNATE CARTHAGINIAN BREASTPLATE



Exotic army
A 16th-century artist's impression of Hannibal's Carthaginian forces attempts to convey their exotic variety of personnel. One of the uses of a war elephant may have been as a mobile command post.